toward the market – the type of signal that was necessary to placate the pressures coming from reform advocates – when in fact, the government never intended to follow that path." Cuba's failure to go further meant that what happened in Cuba was "stealth statism" or "the pretense of market reforms."[13]

Archibald Ritter agrees that the Special Period is over, but he does not see this ending as simply a return to the past. Ritter describes the current reformulation – what he calls the "grand design" – in the following terms:

> The central feature of the "grand design" is a new basis for the generation of foreign exchange earnings now emphasizing nickel, medical and educational services, and, in time, perhaps petroleum. It emphasizes Cuba as a "knowledge economy and society" producing high value services for Latin America and the world. The older economic foundation – remittances, tourism, and lesser merchandise exports – will of course continue, but will be given less emphasis. The new economic master-plan also includes a stronger centralized control of the economy as well as "socialist purification" and a shoring up of the basic infrastructure necessary for sustained economic expansion and prosperity, so far emphasizing the energy sector.[14]

Thus Ritter describes the current situation not as a reversal and an end of reform, but rather a new phase in an ongoing process of economic experimentation. Some Cuban economists had been arguing since the 1990s that Cuba's advantages, and its future, should rest on its human capital. Rather than competing with other poor countries in a race to the bottom to offer low-wage workers to manufacturing companies, or cheap vacations to foreigners, Cuba should compete in the international playing field with its special strengths: its natural beauty – ecotourism; its doctors and professionals – health tourism, export of doctors, and attracting foreign students; and its skilled and educated workforce – promoting exports in biotechnology, medications, and other high-value products.[15] Much of what Ritter sees happening in the post-2005 reforms seems to lead in this direction.